

Brand Voice Guide

Cymbal Voyages Brand Studio · Agency onboarding packet · Last updated September 2026

Who we are

Cymbal Voyages is a mid-size online travel brand. We sell flights, hotels and curated trip packages, and we run a loyalty program called Cymbal Compass. We started a little over a decade ago as a small team that planned winter getaways for friends who were tired of the cold, and that origin still shapes the business. Our signature category is the warm escape: a winter or early-spring trip to the Caribbean, Mexico, Hawaii, Central America or the Florida Keys, booked by someone in Chicago, Boston, Minneapolis, Detroit, Denver, Toronto, Cleveland or Milwaukee who has been watching the forecast since August. We also sell city breaks, ski trips, adventure itineraries and cruises. But when a customer thinks of us, we want them to feel the first warm afternoon of a trip they planned months ago.

We are not the biggest travel site and we do not try to sound like one. We compete on knowing our customers, on curating fewer, better options, and on a loyalty program that treats a returning member like someone we remember.

What we believe about travel

A trip starts the day you book it. The months of looking forward are part of what you are buying, so we treat the planning phase with the same care as the arrival. That is why we talk about "planning your escape" rather than "grabbing a deal."

Specifics beat adjectives. A customer deciding between Aruba and St. Lucia wants to know that Aruba sits outside the hurricane belt and that St. Lucia's beaches are on the leeward side. Telling them either one is stunning helps nobody.

Price matters, and honesty about price matters more. We show what a trip costs per person, with taxes and fees, before anyone enters a card number. We do not make people hunt for the real number.

Loyalty is a relationship, not a discount. Members come back because we remember what they like and because points feel like recognition. Our history shows that a sitewide percent-off sale reads as a coupon to exactly the customers who value us most, and it costs us margin without earning us anything lasting.

How we sound

Four principles govern every piece of copy we produce. When two of them pull in different directions, the earlier one wins.

Warm without gushing. We write the way a well-travelled friend talks: pleased for you, interested in your plans, and never selling too hard. Warmth lives in attention to the reader's situation ("It has been a long February"), not in intensifiers. We do not use exclamation points. We do not use emoji.

Specific over sweeping. Name the beach, the month, the flight time, the number of points. A sentence with one concrete detail is worth three sentences of atmosphere. If a claim cannot be checked, cut it.

Quietly confident. We know our destinations and we say so plainly. We do not need superlatives to prove it, and we do not compare ourselves to other companies in customer-facing copy. Confidence shows in short declarative sentences and in the absence of hedging words like "amazing," "incredible" and "ultimate."

Plain about money. Prices, points, expiry dates and conditions appear in the same voice as the rest of the copy, not buried in a footnote. We say "from \$1,240 per person, taxes and fees included" and we mean it.

Sentence rhythm matters as much as word choice. Mix short declarative sentences with longer ones that carry a detail. Second person is welcome ("you"); the brand speaks as "we." Avoid the contrast construction in which a sentence denies a plain description in order to assert a grander one; it has become a tic across the category and it makes us sound like everyone else. Say the grander thing directly, or better, say the specific thing.

Words we use

We say	Why
warm escape	Our signature category, named plainly. Use it in customer-facing copy and in briefs.
plan your escape	The call to action that fits our belief that the trip starts at booking. Strongest with lapsed members.
curated	We choose fewer, better options and say so. Use it once per piece at most.
per person, taxes and fees included	The price frame we lead with. See the legal claims list for the full disclaimer.
bonus points, double points	Loyalty language that reads as recognition rather than discount.
welcome back	The two words that matter most to a lapsed member.
shoulder season, hurricane season	We name the weather honestly. Customers trust us more for it.

Words we don't use

We avoid	Say this instead
guaranteed lowest price, cheapest	"from \$X per person" with the price disclaimer
best in the world, #1, world-class	a specific, checkable detail about the place
risk-free	the actual cancellation terms, stated plainly
always	the specific timeframe or condition
unforgettable, breathtaking, paradise	describe what the reader will see or do
hidden gem, bucket list, once-in-a-lifetime	the name of the place and one reason to go
amazing, incredible, ultimate, epic	cut the adjective; the noun can carry the sentence
hurry, last chance, don't miss out	the real deadline, stated once ("book by October 31")
deal-hunter language: steal, slash, blowout	"offer," "free night," "bonus points"

The full banned list with substitutions lives in the legal claims list. The Brand Studio agent should treat the left column above as a hard block.

Tone by channel

Channel	How the voice flexes
Email	The most personal channel. Address the reader's situation and history. One idea per send. Subject lines under 45 characters, no urgency words.
Paid social	Visual first. Copy is a caption, not a pitch: one line of context, one call to action. Beach-couple imagery for lapsed members; city skylines for urban explorers.
Paid search	Functional and exact. Destination, price frame, one differentiator (curated packages, Compass points). No adjectives that would fail legal review.
Organic (site and content)	Room to be specific. Destination pages run 120 to 200 words and lead with what the place feels like and who it suits.
Direct (site, app, confirmations)	Calm and useful. Confirmations state what was booked, what it cost and what happens next. Cross-sell only after the essentials.

Affiliate	Partners write in their own voice. We supply price frames, disclaimers and destination facts, and we ask that our banned-word list be honored.
-----------	--

Sample sentences

Sentence	Why this works
It has been a long February. Maui in March is 82 degrees and eleven hours of daylight.	Opens with the reader's situation, then answers it with two checkable facts.
Welcome back. We have kept your Compass points, and we have a few ideas for where to spend them.	The lapsed-member tone: remembered, no pressure, points as recognition.
Book a warm escape by October 31 and we will add 5,000 bonus points to your account.	The offer, the deadline and the mechanism in one sentence, no urgency adjectives.
Aruba sits outside the hurricane belt, which is why we send so many first-timers there in September.	Honest about weather, and the "we" carries a quiet expertise.
From \$1,240 per person for four nights, taxes and fees included.	The price frame we lead with, stated the way the legal claims list requires.
Lisbon is a good city for walking, provided you like hills.	Specific, a little wry, and it helps the reader decide rather than flattering the place.
Three nights in Montréal, an easy flight from Toronto, and a Saturday morning at the Jean-Talon market.	A city-break sentence made of nouns. Nothing to review, nothing to cut.
Your points expire after 24 months without activity. A booking, any size, resets the clock.	Plain about money. The second sentence turns a rule into help.
We chose this resort for its calm water. It suits families with young swimmers.	"Curated" shown rather than claimed, and the reader learns who the place suits.
The Alaska Inside Passage sails in June and July. May departures are cooler and quieter.	Presents a real trade-off instead of pushing a single answer.
Two free nights on February departures to Punta Cana, while they last.	An honest scarcity frame: the inventory is limited, and we say so without a countdown.

Before and after

Before	After	What changed
Don't miss our BIGGEST sale ever. Up to 40% off paradise destinations. Book now before it's gone.	Winter departures to the Caribbean and Mexico, from \$1,180 per person, taxes and fees included. Book by October 31.	Removed superlatives, banned words and urgency. Added the price frame and the real deadline.
Experience the unforgettable magic of the ultimate Hawaiian getaway.	Kauai in February: warm mornings on the north shore, quiet trails above Hanalei, and about twelve hours of daylight.	Replaced adjectives with the place, the month and three concrete details.
We miss you. Come back and get 15% off everything sitewide. Offer ends in 48 hours.	Welcome back. Book a warm escape by January 15 and we will add 5,000 bonus points to your Compass account.	Lapsed-member tone: remembered, rewarded with points, no coupon, no countdown.
Our world-class, #1-rated resort partners guarantee the lowest prices in the industry.	We choose each resort ourselves, and the price you see includes taxes and fees.	Dropped claims that would fail legal review and replaced them with two things we can stand behind.
A once-in-a-lifetime bucket-list adventure in breathtaking Patagonia. Unforgettable.	Torres del Paine in March: the crowds have thinned, the weather is still workable, and the W Trek takes four days.	Removed four banned phrases. Kept the destination and gave the reader something to plan around.

A closing test

If a sentence would embarrass a well-travelled friend, cut it. If a claim could not survive a

customer checking it, cut it. If the copy would read the same under any other travel brand's logo, start over.